

Travelling to Australia with an assistance cat

We are reforming the import pathway for assistance animals to include cats.

In the interim, we can consider import permit applications for assistance cats.

Contact us for guidance on travelling with your assistance cat via email (imports@aff.gov.au)

All assistance dogs coming to Australia must meet import conditions.

This applies to:

- Australian dogs returning to Australia
- dogs travelling to Australia from overseas.

Eligible assistance dogs are defined in the [Biosecurity Regulation 2016](#).

They are dogs that are professionally trained to assist a person with disability. A medical practitioner must provide evidence that a person needs an assistance dog.

Taking your assistance dog on a cruise ship?

This information does not apply to Australian assistance dogs travelling on a cruise ship within Australian waters. See [travelling with assistance dogs on a cruise ship](#).

You cannot travel to Australia with your assistance dog on an international cruise ship. Assistance dogs must travel to Australia via aircraft.

Before you travel

You can only import your assistance dog into Australia from an approved country.

Assistance dogs travelling from most approved countries will need an import permit to enter Australia.

Importing a dog to Australia is a complex process. It may take around 6 months (or more) to complete. You must make sure your dog meets a range of import conditions. This includes multiple veterinary visits, checks and treatments.

Check our [step-by-step guide](#) for your country of export. The guide will help you through the process of importing your dog. Dogs that do not meet these conditions cannot be imported into Australia.

[pet transport agent or shipper](#). We cannot recommend specific pet transport agents or companies.

Reasonable adjustments

In line with the Disability Discrimination Act 1992, we will consider applying reasonable adjustments as part of the import permit application process.

Any reasonable adjustments provided will need to ensure biosecurity risk is adequately managed. This will be unique to each individual handler's application.

You must also meet all standard import conditions to be eligible for any reasonable adjustments made to the import conditions. This includes completing any additional forms or declarations.

If your dog arrives non-compliant with any import conditions these adjustments may be revoked. Your dog may be directed to our quarantine facility or re-exported at your expense.

Australian assistance dogs

If you are planning to travel with your Australian assistance dog you may be able to complete some preparations before you leave Australia.

See more on [cats and dogs returning to Australia](#).

Short stay travel adjustments

Australian dogs travelling overseas for less than 45 days may be exempt from some testing and treatments.

Your dog may also be eligible for short-stay conditions if:

- your dog is of Australian origin, and
- you plan to travel outside of Australia for less than 45 days.

When you complete your import permit application, let us know that you're planning on travelling for less than 45 days. We will consider whether further adjustments can be made to the import conditions for your assistance dog.

New Zealand and Norfolk Island

Assistance dogs travelling from New Zealand and Norfolk Island do not need import permits. They also do not need to spend time in post entry quarantine on arrival to Australia.

You can request reasonable adjustments such as in-cabin travel or waiving fees. Do this when you email the relevant regional office to notify them of your arrival.

Check the:

- [step-by-step guide to bringing cats and dogs from New Zealand](#)
- [step-by-step guide to bringing cats and dogs from Norfolk Island](#).

See more on [bringing cats and dogs to or from Norfolk Island](#).

Gather your evidence

To apply for reasonable adjustments to the import process, you must provide evidence of:

- your medical need for an assistance dog
- training that the assistance dog has completed.

You provide this evidence with your import permit application.

Medical evidence

Evidence of your medical need for an assistance dog must be documented by your health practitioner. They can be a general practitioner, medical specialist or clinical psychologist.

You do not need to provide in-depth details of your disability.

Medical history form for assistance dog handlers

Your health practitioner will need to complete our medical history form.

Training evidence

You must provide evidence of your dog's training from an:

- international training organisation such as the Assistance Dogs International (ADI) or International Guide Dog Federation (IGDF) or
- Australian state or territory lawfully recognised authority for the accreditation of assistance animals (for example, the government agency responsible for issuing public transport passes) or
- organisation outside of these institutions that can supply training records.

We will assess your dog's training certificates for suitability when you apply for an import permit.

Assistance dog training form

This form must be completed by a representative of the training institution. You need to attach evidence of your dog's certification or accreditation.

Submit your permit application

For assistance dogs that need an import permit, apply through our [Biosecurity Import Conditions System \(BICON\)](#).

In BICON:

- Search for 'Assistance Dog' and select the country of export.
- Read the import conditions. At the end of the page, select 'Apply Now'.

- You will be directed to a page to apply for an import permit. This page is titled ‘Permit Type – Domestic dog’.
- Complete your application. Attach all required documents to apply for reasonable adjustments to the import process.

For more support, see our detailed instructions on [how to apply for an import permit](#).

If you are not eligible for reasonable adjustments to the import process, you may be offered a standard import permit for companion animals.

A standard import permit will attract [fees and charges](#). This includes fees and charges for the on-arrival assessments and the quarantine period in our post-entry quarantine facility.

Applying for an import permit does not guarantee you will be issued one.

If you need help, contact us on:

- 1800 900 090 (within Australia)
- +61 3 8318 6700 (outside Australia)
- imports@aff.gov.au

Travel to Australia

You must notify us of your arrival and arrange for an on-arrival inspection at least 3 working days prior to your intended arrival. Email the regional office in the state or territory where your dog will first arrive.

Your notification email must include a copy of a valid:

- import permit (if applicable)
- veterinary health certificate, completed by an official government vet in the country of export.
- all other required information as per the relevant import conditions.

If you are acting on behalf of an assistance dog handler, ensure that you include their name.

Check the office contacts in Australia for the relevant email address to use.

Office contacts in Australia

- New South Wales – ceranimalimports@aff.gov.au
- Victoria – seanimal@aff.gov.au AND VIC.Controller@aff.gov.au
- Queensland – qldliveanimalimports@aff.gov.au
- South Australia – cargosa@aff.gov.au
- Western Australia – animalswa@aff.gov.au
- Tasmania – tas.controller@aff.gov.au
- Northern Territory – ntliveanimalimports@aff.gov.au
- Australian Capital Territory – actregoffice@aff.gov.au

- General enquiry: imports@aff.gov.au or 1800 900 090 or + 61 3 8318 6700 (from outside Australia).

See a [list of contacts for each regional export office](#).

When you land in Australia

A department veterinary officer and/or a biosecurity officer will meet you and inspect your dog. They will review the import conditions relevant to your dog and will tell you what you need to do once you arrive, and they have finished their inspection and assessment.

Generally, if your dog meets all import requirements, your next steps will depend on the country of export.

If you arrive from a Group 1 country and your dog is compliant with the import conditions:

- your dog will be released from biosecurity control and can leave the port of arrival.

If you arrive Group 2 or Group 3 countries and your dog is compliant with the pre-arrival import conditions:

- Your import permit will detail your dog's quarantine restrictions.
- A department veterinary officer and/or a biosecurity officer will tell you what you need to do next
- Your dog will not be released from quarantine without approval from us.

Exporting your assistance dog from Australia

If you reside in Australia and wish to travel overseas with your assistance dog, you must comply with:

- Australia's export conditions
- the importing country's conditions.

See more on [exporting companion animals](#).

If your dog resides in Australia and you plan to take them to a Group 3 country, you can prepare your dog before you leave. These preparations will make it easier to return to Australia with your dog.

See more on [dogs returning to Australia](#).

Contact us for advice on how to export your assistance dog:

- 1800 900 090 (within Australia)
- +61 3 8318 6700 (outside Australia)
- livestockexp@aff.gov.au